
LECTURE 10: LEARNING

1. What Is Learning?

Slide Definition (Restated Clearly)

Learning refers to:

- how **behavior changes** within an individual's lifespan
- everything we know that is **not genetically given**
- our ability to **predict the future** based on past experiences
- how we **give meaning** to the world
- studying learning **scientifically** through psychology

Example

You couldn't walk, talk, or read as an infant. These abilities were learned over time.

2. Types of Learning (Slide List)

1. **Classical Conditioning**
 2. **Operant Conditioning**
 3. **Observational Learning**
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3. Classical Conditioning

Definition (Slide Idea)

Learning occurs by **associating** one stimulus with another.

Slide Example: Song & Memories

A song played during an important life moment (e.g., meeting someone special) becomes associated with that memory.

Hearing the song later triggers the same feelings.

Explanation

Two unrelated things become connected in your mind.

4. Ivan Pavlov (1849–1936)

Slide Points

- Won **Nobel Prize** for research on **digestion reflexes**.
- Food in the mouth → **automatic salivation**.
- Named these **reflexes**.
- Noticed dogs salivated at the **sight of food** or **feeder** → called “**psychic secretions**” or **conditioned reflexes**.

Experiment Highlights

- Cut esophagus so food couldn't reach stomach
- Still produced gastric juices just from seeing food

→ Indicates learning by association

5. Pavlovian Conditioning Elements

Slide Diagram (Explained Clearly)

Component	Meaning	Example
UCS (Unconditioned Stimulus)	Naturally causes a response	Food
UCR (Unconditioned Response)	Natural reaction	Salivation to food
CS (Conditioned Stimulus)	Neutral initially, later causes response	Bell
CR (Conditioned Response)	Learned reaction to CS	Salivation to bell

Final Association

Bell (CS) → Salivation (CR)

6. The Little Albert Experiment

Slide Idea

A baby (Little Albert) was conditioned to fear a white rat by pairing it with a loud noise.

Explanation

Demonstrated classical conditioning in humans.

7. Operant / Instrumental Conditioning

Definition (From Slide)

Behavior **operates** as an **instrument** to produce outcomes.

Key Researcher: E. L. Thorndike (1898)

Puzzle Box Experiment

- Cat had to pull a latch to escape
- Used **trial and error**
- Over time → fewer errors (learned)

Law of Effect (Slide Point)

The **consequence** of a behavior determines whether it increases or decreases.

Consequence Effect on Behavior

Reward Strengthened

No Reward Weakened

Punishment Very weakened

Example

If a cat escapes faster after reward → behavior strengthens.

8. B. F. Skinner (1904–1990)

Slide Points

- Behavior is shaped by **consequences**
 - An **operant response** is an action that affects the environment
 - Operant behavior is **voluntary**, unlike reflexes in classical conditioning
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9. Reinforcement & Punishment

Important Slide Definitions

- **Reinforcement** → increases behavior
- **Punishment** → decreases behavior

Both can be **positive** (adding) or **negative** (removing).

10. Types of Reinforcers (Slide Table)

Primary Reinforcers:

- Food
- Water
- Relief from pain

Secondary Reinforcers:

- Money
- Praise
- Attention
- Promotions
- Admission/tokens

Partial Reinforcement

- Behavior is rewarded **sometimes**, not always
- Makes behavior **more resistant to extinction**

Graph Slide Summary

30% reinforced group kept responding longer than 100% reinforced group.

11. Positive vs Negative Reinforcement

Positive Reinforcement

Adding something pleasant to increase behavior.

Example: Child gets tablet time after finishing homework.

Negative Reinforcement

Removing something unpleasant to increase behavior.

Example: Turning phone to silent mode to remove distractions.

12. Positive vs Negative Punishment

Positive Punishment

Adding something negative to reduce behavior.

Example: Receiving a fine for speeding.

Negative Punishment

Removing something desirable to reduce behavior.

Example: Taking a teenager's phone for poor grades.

13. Observational Learning

Definition (Slide)

Learning by **observing and modeling** others' behaviors, attitudes, or emotional expressions.

Albert Bandura emphasized:

- You learn by watching, even without copying.
- **Four conditions** are required:

Bandura's Four Processes

1. **Attention** – Notice the model
2. **Retention** – Remember what was observed
3. **Reproduction** – Ability to perform the behavior
4. **Motivation** – Reason to imitate

Example

A child learns to tie shoes by watching a parent.

14. Discussion Question (from Slide)

“Discuss a time when you learned something by classical conditioning, operant conditioning, or observational learning.”

FINAL SUMMARY TABLE (Slide-Accurate)

Topic	Key Points
Learning	Behavior change from experience
3 Types	Classical, Operant, Observational
Classical Conditioning	Association learning (Pavlov, Little Albert)
Operant Conditioning	Behavior shaped by consequences (Thorndike, Skinner)
Reinforcement	Increases behavior
Punishment	Decreases behavior
Positive/Negative	Adding or removing something
Observational Learning	Attention, retention, reproduction, motivation
